

Shohei Toyoda

Head of Audio Business
at Sony India



Audio in focus

In conversation with Shohei Toyoda, Head of Audio Business at Sony India, about Sony's plan of action for 2023, and how 2022 shaped up to be for the company in the audio segment

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With 2022 coming to a close, we can reflect back on some of the best audio tech in 2022 and one company that would come up without question in India is Sony. The company has been dominating the Active Noise Cancellation audio segment in India with fantastic launches in the WH-1000 and WF-1000 series. Active Noise Cancellation is a vital feature that a number of users are actively searching for headphones in 2022. However, with companies such as Sennheiser, Jabra, Bose, and others stepping up their game – it is imperative that Sony stays ahead of the curve to keep the edge they currently have. Recently, we had a chat with Shohei Toyoda, Head of Audio Business at Sony India, who gave us insight into how 2022 has

been for the company's audio division, their plans for 2023, and other exciting technologies Sony has been implementing into their audio devices. Let's delve right into it.

Q How much has the home audio industry grown in India? Is the demand higher since the pandemic or has it dropped now that WFH has started to come to an end?

A The need to have an elevated entertainment experience has been on consumers' minds for a long time however the stay-at-home period in the last couple of years has induced this demand even further. Hence, we are witnessing a positive shift in consumer demand toward home audio products. The trend can be attributed to the need for upgrading home entertainment as people are spending more and more time at home and want their home entertainment experience to

be more high quality and immersive. Some of the other factors that have fuelled this growth are economic activities gaining momentum, deeper penetration of OTT content, increase in social interaction of consumers and the role of these entertainment devices in facilitating the same, influential buying through word of mouth, social media attraction and e-commerce sales. We expect this momentum to continue in the foreseeable future as well.

Q What does 2023 look like for Sony audio products? Are there any new avenues Sony would be stepping into that you can give us some information about?

A We are quite optimistic about both short and mid-term outlook and expect the audio segment to grow in double digits in the next few years. We will continue to launch industry-leading products in the coming years and take home a bigger pie of the market. We will strengthen the Noise-Cancelling segment with our 'Industry Leading' audio products. We have recently launched A-Series premium soundbars which come with 360 Spatial Sound Mapping and 360 Reality Audio technologies. For the strongly growing segment of gaming market in India, we have launched a series of products with sub-brand 'INZONE' that have unique features like Invisible Enemy and 360 surround sound. Not to forget, we have launched SRS-XV900 wireless party speaker which can play up to 25 hours on battery. This segment is rapidly growing, and we would like to expand the product portfolio to capture a major share of this market.

Q The focus of the audio industry seems to have shifted to wireless audio. Is Sony doing anything our readers should take special note of in the wired audio segment?

A Both the wireless and wired audio segments are equally important to Sony as with High-Res Audio wireless, consumers can experience High-Resolution sound quality on devices designed for LDAC. LDAC provides an enhanced wireless listening experi-